

Creating a gradient mask is as simple as using the gradient tool—just configure it as you would do so for any other purpose, and instead of filling the layer with the gradient, just fill the mask.

Clipping masks

You will often encounter this term—a clipping mask is when you use one layer as a mask for another. Clipping masks don't pay attention to greyscale—the image is either there or not.

When you create a clipping mask for a layer, the layer below it becomes the mask. Where the lower layer has image data (this could be a brush stroke, a shape, anything), the layer shows through, otherwise it doesn't.

To create a clipping mask, go to Layer > Create Clipping Mask or hold down [Alt] and click on the dividing line between the two layers. You will notice that the cursor shape changes before you click the divider.

Unlike layer masks, clipping masks aren't linked to the layer they are masking—you will have to do this yourself if you intend for the two layers to move together.

All this talk about masks isn't going to get us anywhere till we sit down and do something with them, so here are a couple of workshops to get you going.



The brighter picture on top shows through only inside the shape below it